AVÈRO ADVISORS

TEMPLATE 04

START AT ZERO TOOLKIT · TEMPLATE 04

Vendor Evaluation Scorecard

A seven-category weighted scorecard that rewards evidence over theater: functional fit, architecture, implementation, viability, TCO, scripted demos and references.

A county once fell for a flawless demo. When the independent advisors asked both finalists to run three of the county's own scenarios, the polished vendor could not finish two of them. A perfect demo predicts a perfect demo, nothing more. This scorecard keeps the decision anchored to evidence across seven weighted categories.

Before anyone scores

- **Lock the weights before the RFP is released.** Changing them after proposals arrive invites a protest and a headline.
- **Apply pass/fail gates first:** mandatory requirements, insurance and bonding, key terms, and conflicts of interest.
- **Score independently, then calibrate.** Each evaluator scores alone before any group discussion.
- **Write the evidence.** Every score needs a sentence explaining why.

Seven categories and suggested weights

Category	Weight	Range	What to examine	Evidence source
1. Functional fit	**25**	20-30	• Coverage of your prioritized requirements with standard configuration • Fit for your real workflows from Phase Zero, including the exceptions • Workarounds or bespoke software needed to close gaps, and who maintains them	Requirements response, scenario demo, configuration evidence
2. Technical architecture and integration	**15**	10-20	• Integration approach and APIs for your interface inventory • Security, identity, audit logging and data residency • Embedded vs. composable AI, and your ability to turn features off	Architecture review, security questionnaire, technical session
3. Implementation approach and team	**15**	10-20	• Realism of the plan, staffing and agency effort assumptions • Named key personnel with public sector experience, and substitution terms • Data conversion, testing and training approach	Implementation plan, resumes, key personnel interviews
4. Vendor viability and track record	**10**	5-15	• Financial stability and ownership changes • Comparable public sector go-lives in the last five years • Product roadmap commitments in writing, not slides	Financials, client list, roadmap documentation
5. Ten-year total cost of ownership	**15**	10-20	• Licenses, hosting and escalators over ten years • Implementation, change orders history, and agency backfill • Training, data cleansing, support and exit costs	Cost proposal normalized to your TCO model

Category	Weight	Range	What to examine	Evidence source
6. Scripted scenario demonstration	**10**	10-15	• Completes your scenarios with your data, not a golden path • Shows what is configuration and what is future roadmap • Real users can complete tasks without the presenter driving	Scripted demo scored live by each evaluator
7. References	**10**	5-15	• References you found, not only the vendor's list • Timeline and budget variance at those agencies • Answer to: Knowing what you know now, would you select them again?	Structured reference interviews
TOTAL	**100**	**ADJUST WITHIN THE RANGES TO MATCH YOUR PRIORITIES, THEN FREEZE.**		

Scoring scale

0	1	2	3	4	5
Not offered or no evidence	Major gaps	Partially meets, significant workarounds	Meets with standard configuration	Meets well, minor configuration	Exceeds, proven at a comparable agency

Score sheet

Weighted score = weight × raw score ÷ 5. Maximum total is 100.

Category	Weight	Vendor A raw	A weighted	Vendor B raw	B weighted	Vendor C raw	C weighted
1. Functional fit	25						
2. Technical architecture and integration	15						
3. Implementation approach and team	15						
4. Vendor viability and track record	10						
5. Ten-year total cost of ownership	15						
6. Scripted scenario demonstration	10						
7. References	10						
TOTAL	**100**						

Evaluator notes

Category	Evidence behind the score (one sentence each)
1. Functional fit	
2. Technical architecture and integration	
3. Implementation approach and team	
4. Vendor viability and track record	

Category	Evidence behind the score (one sentence each)
5. Ten-year total cost of ownership	
6. Scripted scenario demonstration	
7. References	

Calibration rules

- A spread of more than 2 points between evaluators on any category triggers a discussion before final scores.
- Evaluators may change a score only by writing down new evidence.
- The facilitator (ideally independent) does not score.
- Price is opened after technical scoring is complete.

Red flags

- The vendor will not run your scenarios with your data.
- Key personnel in the proposal are not the people in the room.
- Every reference was hand-picked by the vendor.
- TCO leaves out backfill, data cleansing or training.
- Critical AI features exist only on the roadmap.

Sign-off

Role	Name	Signature	Date
Evaluation chair			
Independent facilitator			
Executive Sponsor			

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